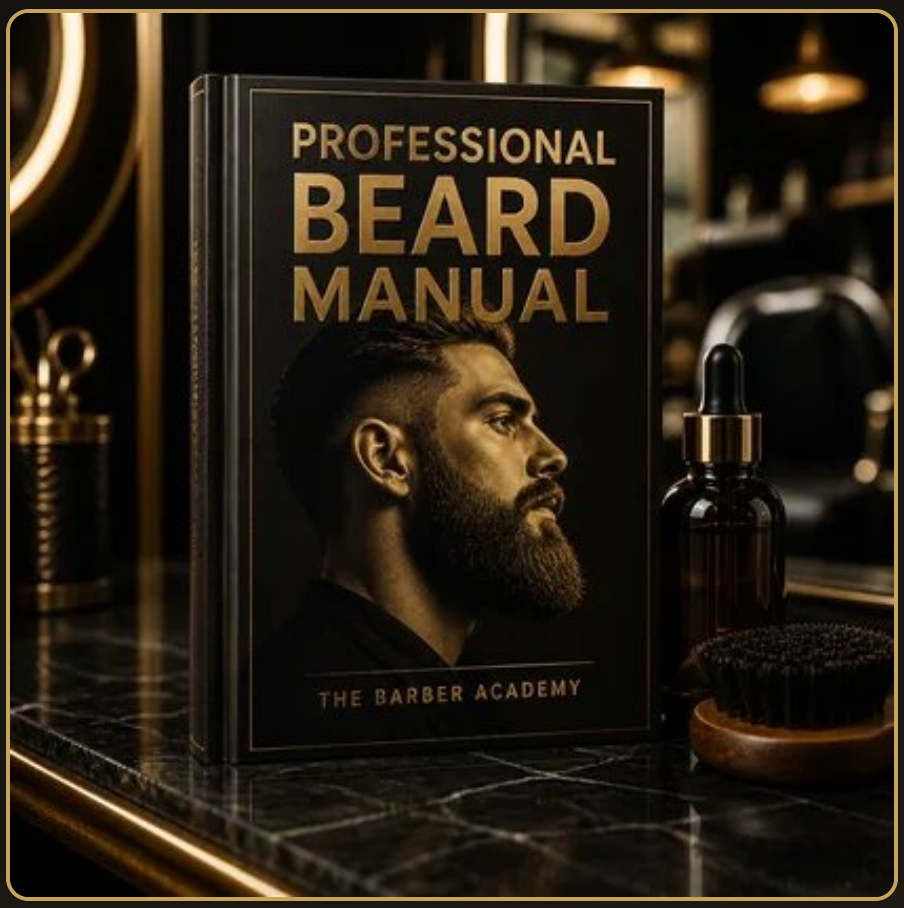
BONUS 3

Professional Beard Manual

Shape, trim and care for every beard



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> *Beard work is where a good barber separates from an average one. A haircut grows out in weeks, but a beard sits front and center on the face, and every line you draw is visible in every conversation your client has. This manual walks you through the full process: reading the face, preparing the skin, shaping, fading, finishing, and sending the client home with a plan. Take it one section at a time and practice each step slowly before you try to speed up.*

Safety and licensing first

Beard services involve sharp tools and close contact with skin. Disinfect every tool between clients, use a fresh single-use blade for every razor service, wash your hands before and after each client, and wear gloves when the service calls for it. In many places you need a barber or cosmetology license to charge for services. Check your local licensing requirements before working on paying clients. The Certificate of Completion that comes with this course is not a license.

1. Beard Types and Face Shapes

Before you pick up a trimmer, decide what beard the face and the hair can actually support. A beard works with the bone structure underneath it. The right shape adds balance, and the wrong one exaggerates whatever the client already dislikes about his face.

Reading the face shape

Look at the client straight on, then from each side. Note the widest point of the face, the length of the jaw, and how strong the chin is. Most faces fall into one of six broad shapes. Use the table as a starting point, not a rule. Real faces are mixtures, and the client's preference counts as much as geometry.

FACE SHAPE	WHAT YOU SEE	BEARD GOAL	GOOD STARTING STYLES
Oval	Balanced length and width, soft jaw	Keep proportions; almost anything works	Short boxed, full, van dyke
Round	Full cheeks, soft jaw, similar width and length	Add length and angles; avoid width at the cheeks	Longer chin, tight sides, anchor, goatee
Square	Strong, wide jaw, flat forehead	Soften or keep the strength depending on the client	Full with rounded corners, short boxed
Oblong	Long face, high forehead, narrow cheeks	Add width at the sides; avoid extra length on the chin	Full with fuller sides, short boxed
Heart	Wide forehead, narrow pointed chin	Add weight at the jaw and chin	Full beard, fuller chin, light stubble
Diamond	Wide cheekbones, narrow forehead and chin	Fill the chin and jaw, soften the cheeks	Full with rounded cheek line, anchor

The main beard styles

- **Stubble:** very short growth, about 1 to 3 mm, usually with clean edges.
- **Trimmed beard:** even growth kept short with a sharp cheek line and neckline.
- **Short boxed beard:** a squared, structured shape, with a controlled length and defined edges.
- **Full beard:** natural length over the cheeks, jaw, chin and neck, shaped but not restricted.
- **Goatee:** hair on the chin, with or without a mustache connection.
- **Van dyke:** a pointed chin beard and a separate mustache, with clean cheeks.
- **Anchor:** a beard that follows the jawline and chin, with a mustache connecting to it, drawn like a ship's anchor.

> **Tip**
> Ask the client to show you a photo of what he likes. A picture is faster and more accurate than words like 'short on the sides' or 'not too neat'.

2. Anatomy and Growth of Facial Hair

Facial hair is thicker and coarser than scalp hair, and it grows in different directions across the face. Understanding that makes your tool movements predictable.

Growth patterns

- On the cheeks the hair usually grows downward and slightly forward.
- On the neck it often grows downward at the top and can turn sideways or upward lower down.
- Around the chin and under the lip the direction can swirl, which creates cowlicks.
- Mustache hair generally grows downward and outward from the center.

Hair grows roughly half an inch per month, but the rate and density vary by client, age and genetics. Some men grow dense hair on the cheeks and thin hair on the chin. Others show patches. Your job is to design around reality, not around an ideal.

Skin and follicle basics

Each hair grows from a follicle, a small pocket in the skin. Coarse and curly hair can curl back into the skin after shaving, causing irritation. Skin type matters too: dry skin flakes under the beard, oily skin can clog follicles, and sensitive skin reacts to heat, friction and strong products.

> **Tip**
> Run your fingers through the beard against the grain before you start. You will feel the direction changes, cowlicks and thin areas that you cannot always see.

3. The Client Consultation

A two-minute consultation prevents most mistakes. Do it with the client seated, the cape not yet on, facing a mirror.

1. Ask what he wants: length, shape, how much maintenance he is willing to do at home.
2. Ask about skin conditions, allergies, recent irritation, or past reactions to products.
3. Check the beard: density, patches, direction, scars, moles, and any bumps or sores.
4. Show your plan using the mirror and your fingers: where the cheek line goes, where the neckline goes, what length you will leave.
5. Agree on guard numbers before you cut. If you are unsure, start longer.

> **Warn**
>
> If you see an open wound, active infection, widespread rash, or anything that looks unusual, do not perform the service. Politely suggest he see a doctor or other health professional.

4. Tools of the Trade

You do not need many tools, but you need the right ones in good condition. Describe tools by type, not by brand: what matters is how they behave in the hand.

TOOL	USED FOR	NOTES
Corded or cordless clipper	Taking down length, fades, bulk removal	Use guards from #0 to #8; check the blade for sharpness
Trimmer (detailer)	Outlines, cheek line, neckline, mustache edges	Close-cutting blades give crisp lines; keep it clean and oiled
Barber shears	Cutting length at the chin, scissor-over-comb work	Keep them sharp and use them only on hair
Straight razor or shavette with single-use blades	Shaving cheeks, neck, and line work	Always use a fresh blade per client
Beard comb and fine-tooth comb	Detangling, guiding length, scissor-over-comb	Anti-static, with both wide and fine teeth
Beard brush	Spreading oil, training hair, removing loose hair	Natural bristles are gentler
Neck duster brush	Clearing hair from skin	Disinfect between clients
Hot towels and towel steamer	Softening hair and opening pores	Fresh towel per client
Beard oil and balm	Finishing and conditioning	Describe by ingredient type, patch test when in doubt

TOOL	USED FOR	NOTES
Pre-shave oil and shave cream or soap	Protection and glide	Lather in a brush for an even coat

5. Preparation and Hygiene

Good preparation makes the whole service smoother and safer. Never skip it, even for a quick trim.

Your station and your hands

- Wash your hands with soap and water before each client.
- Lay out clean, disinfected tools on a clean surface. Open single-use razor blades in front of the client.
- Wear gloves for razor work and whenever you see broken skin or skin irritation.
- Use a fresh neck strip and a clean cape.

Preparing the beard and skin

1. Wash or comb out the beard to remove product, dirt and tangles. Dry beards cut more evenly.
2. Apply a warm towel for one to two minutes to soften hair and open the skin. Test the temperature on your own wrist first.
3. For shaving areas, apply a few drops of pre-shave oil. It protects the skin and helps the razor glide.
4. Build a lather with shave soap or cream, or use a clean foam. Apply with a brush in small circles against the growth, then smooth with the growth.

> **Tip**
> If the towel is too hot for your wrist, it is too hot for the face. Better a little cool than a little burnt.

6. Mapping the Lines: Cheek Line and Neckline

Lines are what make a beard look intentional. A messy line ruins a good fade, and a clean line rescues a simple beard.

The cheek line

The cheek line is the upper edge of the beard. A natural cheek line follows the cheekbone curve, starting near the sideburn and ending near the corner of the mouth. Most clients look best with the line starting around the middle of the ear and curving to the corner of the mouth, but it varies.

1. Have the client look straight ahead and relax his face.
2. Find the highest natural point where the hair is dense and decide where you want it. A line that is too high looks artificial.
3. Mark the line lightly with a trimmer or a comb as a guide, working from sideburn to mouth.

4. Trim everything above the line with the trimmer, moving in short, controlled strokes.
5. Check both sides in the mirror. They should match.

The neckline: the two-finger rule

The neckline defines where the beard ends and the neck begins. Placed too high, the beard looks small. Placed too low, it looks messy and heavy.

1. Ask the client to lift his head slightly and look straight ahead.
2. Place two fingers, held together, above the Adam's apple. The line should sit about one to two fingers above it.
3. Curve the line up toward each ear, in a smooth U shape that follows the jaw, not a straight line across.
4. Remove everything below the line with a trimmer or razor.
5. Check from the side. The line should be level and connect cleanly behind the jaw.

> **Tip**
> Two fingers above the Adam's apple is a guide, not a law. Leave a little more beard when the neck is long or the beard is very full. Start higher and adjust, because you can always lower a line, but you cannot put hair back.

> **Warn**
> Never run a razor or trimmer across the Adam's apple or the front of the throat without stretching and supporting the skin, and keep your strokes short and controlled.

7. The Beard Fade

A beard fade blends a short beard into the sideburns and hair above, with no visible line between them. It is created with guards, in stages, from short to longer.

Guard reference

GUARD	APPROXIMATE LENGTH	TYPICAL USE
#0 or bare blade	About 0.5 mm (1/16 in)	Bottom of a skin fade at the neck and cheeks
#1	About 3 mm (1/8 in)	Short stubble look, lower part of a fade
#2	About 6 mm (1/4 in)	Middle of the fade
#3	About 10 mm (3/8 in)	Top of the fade where it meets the full beard
#4	About 13 mm (1/2 in)	Short beard length

Guard numbers can differ slightly between clippers. Check yours against a ruler and write down the real lengths.

Step by step

1. Start with the longest guard, usually #3, over the whole beard to even out the length.
2. Switch to #2 and work from the neckline up, stopping about halfway up the cheek. Use a flicking motion, moving the clipper away from the skin as you rise.
3. Switch to #1 and work only on the lower area, from the neckline up to about one inch.
4. If the client wants a skin fade, use the bare blade or #0 for the bottom half inch, then blend back up through #1.
5. Blend the beard into the hair above the ear with the #3 or #2 guard, flicking outward at the top of the sideburn.
6. Check the blend from the front and side. Use a trimmer or comb to soften any lines that remain.

> **Tip**
> Use the lever of the clipper. Open it a bit for the transition area, close it for the lower part. It gives a smoother gradient than switching guards alone.

8. Styles Step by Step

Trimmed beard

1. Comb out the beard and set your overall guard, typically #3 or #4.
2. Run the clipper through with the grain, then against, to even the length.
3. Define the cheek line and the neckline with a trimmer.
4. Clean the mustache edge so it sits just above the lip.
5. Brush, check symmetry, and finish with oil.

Short boxed beard

1. Use a #3 or #4 guard to take the beard down to a uniform length.
2. Square the shape: a straight, level cheek line, a straight vertical sideburn connection, and a defined jaw.
3. Cut the bottom edge with the trimmer along the jaw, leaving it sharp and clean.
4. Straight, structured, nothing wispy. Check from all angles.

Full beard

1. Comb the beard down and cut the length with shears at the chin and clippers on the sides.
2. Keep more length on the chin than on the cheeks to help the face shape.

3. Blend the sides gradually with the guards, no hard transitions.
4. Set the cheek line and neckline high enough to look intentional, not natural and untidy.

Stubble

1. Use a #1 or #2 guard, or a stubble comb attachment, over the whole beard.
2. Clean the neckline sharply, as the beard is short and lines show more.
3. Define the cheek line with a trimmer.
4. Finish with a light moisturizer or balm, never heavy oil.

Goatee

1. Mark the area: from the lower lip down to the chin, with the width of the mouth.
2. Shave or trim everything outside the shape cleanly.
3. Trim the goatee to the chosen length with a guard.
4. Define a sharp edge, and keep the symmetry on both sides of the mouth.

Van dyke

1. Create a separate mustache, trimmed just above the lip, and a pointed chin beard.
2. Keep the cheeks clean-shaven or shaved short.
3. Shape the chin beard into a point, with the sides slightly straight.
4. Make sure there is a gap between the mustache and the chin beard.

Anchor

1. Establish the mustache and connect it to the chin hair along the lower lip, forming the anchor line.
2. Follow the jaw with a thin strip of hair along the jawline, if the client wants it.
3. Clean the cheeks with the razor or trimmer.
4. Keep the line narrow, even and symmetrical.

9. Hot Towel Razor Shave

A traditional razor shave is the highest-skill service in beard work. Take your time. Safety comes before speed, and you should practice on a practice pad and with supervision before you work on real clients, where the law allows.

> **Safety**
>
> Use a fresh single-use blade per client. Wear gloves. Never reuse a blade and never share one. Dispose of used blades in a sharps container. If you cut the skin, stop, put on fresh gloves, apply pressure with clean gauze, and use a product appropriate for minor cuts, following local sanitation rules.

1. Prepare the station and put on gloves. Open a new blade in front of the client.
2. Apply a warm towel to the area for one to two minutes.
3. Apply pre-shave oil, then a warm, even lather.
4. Hold the razor at a shallow angle of about 30 degrees to the skin, with the skin stretched tight with your free hand.
5. Shave with the grain on the first pass, using short, even strokes.
6. Re-lather. For a closer result, do a second pass across the grain, never against it if the client has sensitive skin.
7. Rinse with a warm towel and check by touch for missed spots.
8. Close with a cool towel, then apply a soothing aftershave balm or lotion without heavy alcohol.
9. Dispose of the blade safely, remove your gloves, and wash your hands.

> **Tip**
> Shaving over the same spot too many times causes irritation. Two passes are usually enough.

10. Beard Treatment and Care

What the client does at home decides how the beard looks next week. Teach him a simple routine.

- **Wash:** use a mild cleanser two or three times per week. Daily shampoo can strip natural oils.
- **Conditioning:** follow with a light conditioner for dry or coarse beards.
- **Beard oil:** two to five drops, applied to damp or dry skin and spread through the beard to the skin. It softens the hair and moisturizes the skin underneath.
- **Beard balm:** a thicker product that adds light hold and conditioning. Good for longer beards.
- **Brushing:** a daily brush spreads oil and trains the hair to lie in the right direction.
- **Trimming schedule:** a clean-up every two to four weeks for most styles.

> **Tip**
> Short stubble beards need less product than long beards. Overusing balm on a short beard looks greasy.

11. Common Beard Problems

> **When to refer**
> You are a barber, not a medical professional. If a condition looks infected, painful, scarred, or keeps coming back, recommend the client see a doctor, dermatologist or other health professional. Do not diagnose and do not promise results from any product.

PROBLEM	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	WHAT YOU CAN DO	WHEN TO REFER
Ingrown hairs	Small bumps where hairs curl back into the skin	Avoid very close shaving; shave with the grain; gentle exfoliation; keep skin clean	If painful, swollen or infected
Razor bumps	Red irritated bumps after shaving	Use a fresh blade, shave with the grain, limit passes, use a soothing balm	If persistent or spreading
Patchy beard	Uneven density with bald spots	Keep length even, a slightly longer cut to cover gaps, define lines to look deliberate	If sudden hair loss or a round bare patch appears
Dry skin and flaking	White flakes in the beard, tight skin	Gentle wash, beard oil, moisturizer; avoid hot water	If red, itchy or scaly patches continue
Skin irritation	Redness, burning, itching	Stop the service, soothe with a cool towel	If it persists or spreads

12. Recommending Products

Recommendations should serve the client, not your sales target. Offer only what he needs.

1. Ask what he already uses and what he wants from the beard: softness, hold, shine, scent.
2. Match product type to beard length: stubble needs a light moisturizer, medium beards benefit from oil, long beards from oil and balm.
3. Explain how to use it, how much, and how often.
4. Mention ingredients that matter, such as fragrance-free options for sensitive skin.
5. Never claim a product cures a condition or grows hair. If he asks about hair growth, explain honestly that genetics decide most of it.

> **Tip**
>
> A client who understands how to use a product will come back. A client who bought something he does not understand will not.

13. Finishing and Photos

Final checks

BEFORE THE CLIENT LEAVES THE CHAIR

- ☐ Lines match on both sides
- ☐ Neckline sits level and clean
- ☐ No loose hairs on the skin or collar
- ☐ Skin is not irritated
- ☐ Beard is brushed in the right direction
- ☐ Product applied lightly, not heavy
- ☐ Client approved in the mirror from the front and both sides

Photographing your work

- Ask permission before taking any photo of a client.
- Use natural light or a soft, even light source.
- Take the front, left and right profiles, and one detail shot of the lines.
- Keep the background simple and clean.
- Never post a client's photo without his consent.

14. Client Consultation Sheet

Print this sheet or copy it into your own notes. Fill it out at the start of each beard service.

CONSULTATION SHEET

☐ Client name and date

☐ Face shape (oval, round, square, oblong, heart, diamond)

☐ Growth pattern and density (even, patchy, thin, thick)

☐ Desired style

☐ Guard numbers agreed on top and sides

☐ Cheek line position agreed

☐ Neckline position agreed

☐ Skin condition or allergies noted

☐ Products used at home

☐ Next appointment recommended in ___ weeks

☐ Notes on what worked well

15. Common Mistakes

- Starting without a consultation and guessing what the client wants.
- Cutting the neckline too high or too low.
- Cutting the cheek line too far toward the eye.
- Using a guard that is too short on the first pass.
- Skipping the warm towel and razoring dry skin.
- Reusing a razor blade or failing to disinfect tools.
- Pushing the clipper straight up without flicking out, creating a hard line in the fade.
- Ignoring growth direction and cowlicks.
- Using too much product at the end.
- Leaving without checking symmetry from the front.

> **Tip**
> If you make a mistake, tell the client calmly and offer a solution, such as a shorter style. Honesty builds more trust than hiding it.

16. Weekly Practice Plan

Skill comes from repetition with feedback. Use this plan with a practice mannequin, a willing model, or on supervised clients where local rules allow it.

DAY	FOCUS	GOAL
Day 1	Face shapes and consultation	Practice describing the plan to a friend or mirror
Day 2	Tool handling and sanitation	Set up and disinfect your station in under ten minutes
Day 3	Cheek line and neckline	Draw and trim both lines symmetrically
Day 4	Beard fade with guards	Blend from #3 to #0 smoothly
Day 5	Styles: trimmed, boxed, stubble	Complete two styles with clean lines
Day 6	Razor and hot towel	Practice strokes, angle and tension with supervision
Day 7	Review and photos	Compare your work, note what to improve next week

17. Sanitation and Licensing

Sanitation protects your clients and your reputation. Rules vary by location, so confirm what applies to you.

- Clean tools of visible hair and debris, then disinfect with an approved disinfectant for the required contact time.
- Single-use items such as razor blades, neck strips, and wooden sticks must be thrown away after each client.
- Wash your hands before and after each service.
- Keep towels and capes clean and use them once between washes.
- Store disinfected tools in a clean, closed container.
- Know your local rules for blood exposure and minor cuts.

> **Check local requirements**
>
> Rules about licenses, shop permits, sanitation and which services you can perform differ from place to place. Check your local requirements with the licensing board before you offer services to the public. This manual is educational and the Certificate of Completion is not a license.

18. Handling Difficult Beards

Curly and coarse hair

Curly beards spring back after cutting, so the length you see wet or stretched is shorter than the length you will see when it dries. Cut dry whenever possible and leave a little extra length. Avoid shaving the neck extremely close, because tightly curled hair is the most likely to grow back into the skin. A slightly softer neckline and a single razor pass with the grain lower the chance of irritation.

Gray and thin hair

Gray hair is often wiry and grows in different directions. Thin or light hair shows the skin underneath, so very short guards can look patchy. Leave a bit more length and keep the lines clean so the shape still looks deliberate.

Long beards

With a long beard, start by combing it straight down and cutting the bottom edge with shears, not a clipper, so the shape looks natural. Decide the shape of the bottom: rounded, squared or pointed. Cut a little at a time, comb again, and compare both sides. Keep the neckline and the cheek line sharp, because the contrast between a clean edge and a full beard is what makes it look cared for.

Working around the mustache

The mustache is small but it is the first thing people notice. Comb it down and trim along the lip line with the small scissors or a trimmer, taking care not to touch the lip. Never cut the mustache shorter than the lip line, and keep both sides even. Ask whether the client eats or drinks with it in the way, because some clients prefer it trimmed just above the lip.

> **Tip**
> When in doubt, cut less. A beard can be shaped again at the next visit, but length cannot be glued back on.

19. Working With Different Client Types

- **First-time beard clients:** explain every step, keep the style conservative, and teach a simple home routine.
- **Clients growing out a beard:** do light shaping only, focusing on the neckline and cheek line, so the beard can grow without looking untidy.
- **Clients with sensitive skin:** skip heat, limit razor passes, and choose gentle, fragrance-free products.
- **Clients with a deadline, such as an event:** avoid changing the style drastically right before it, because a mistake has no time to grow back.
- **Regulars:** keep notes on their guard numbers and line positions in the consultation sheet so every visit matches.

Communication is part of the craft. Describe what you are about to do before you do it, especially with the razor, and invite the client to tell you if anything is uncomfortable. A client who feels heard will trust your hands.

20. Setting Up a Safe Service Routine

Consistency protects you. A short routine, repeated the same way every time, prevents forgotten steps.

SERVICE ROUTINE

- ☐ Wash hands and set out disinfected tools
- ☐ Fresh cape, neck strip and towels ready
- ☐ Consultation completed and agreed
- ☐ Prep: comb, warm towel, pre-shave oil where needed
- ☐ Length first, then lines, then fade, then razor
- ☐ Final check from front and both sides
- ☐ Aftercare advice given
- ☐ Tools cleaned and disinfected, blade discarded, station wiped down

Finish every service by cleaning your station before the next client sits down. It looks professional, and it keeps the next client safe.

21. Aftercare Script for the Client

Before the client stands up, give him a short, clear aftercare talk. Keep it to three points so he remembers it.

1. For the next 24 hours, avoid heavy exercise, very hot showers and harsh products on freshly shaved skin, since they can cause redness.
2. Use two to five drops of beard oil each morning, spreading it from the skin outward, and brush it through.
3. Keep the lines at home by only trimming the neck gently when needed, and leave the cheek line for your next visit if he is not confident.

If the skin looks irritated the next day, he should keep it clean, avoid scratching, and see a health professional if it does not improve in a few days.

22. Next Step

Pick one section of this manual and practice it this week. Start with the consultation and the cheek line and neckline. Once those feel natural, move to the beard fade, then to the razor work. Watch the curated video lessons in the course alongside each section, and keep your consultation sheet and practice notes.